

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the eighth time on 17 July 2023.

Members noted the update provided by Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, on progress achieved since the last meeting in attracting, retaining and protecting workers in the agriculture and processing industries, including:

- delivering a new \$2 billion Social Housing Accelerator to alleviate housing shortages across Australia which impact on the ability to attract workers to the agriculture and processing sectors;
- ongoing discussions between Australia and Indonesia to expand the Skills Development Exchange under the Indonesia-Australia Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement into more sectors including agri-business; and
- introducing legislation to amend the Migration Act to protect temporary workers from exploitation.

Members received a presentation from the Hon Clare O'Neil MP, Minister for Home Affairs, on the Outline of the Government's Migration Strategy. Members welcomed the opportunity to provide input directly into the development of the Migration Strategy, including on migration system features of importance to the agriculture and processing sectors and their workers.

Members acknowledged the importance of inclusive workplaces and endorsed two project proposals focused on neurodiverse workers in meat production and processing and First Nations Australians' participation in agriculture respectively, as well as an inclusion factsheet.

Members welcomed ongoing engagement with the Department of Home Affairs on measures to address temporary migrant worker exploitation, including the opportunity to participate in the co-design process for relevant measures.

Members received a presentation from Michael Hartman, CEO of Skills Insight, about its role and workplan as the Agribusiness Jobs and Skills Council. Members reiterated their strong support for the establishment of an agricultural trade apprenticeship and noted the importance of ongoing engagement with Skills Insight on matters relating to workforce skills and data.

Members discussed the importance of anticipating the workforce skills needed for a climate-smart agriculture sector and noted the department would undertake targeted consultation with the sector on its long-term trajectory.

Members acknowledged the contribution of Secretary Metcalfe to the Working Group as well as his distinguished career of public service, in particular his service to the agriculture portfolio.

Members also noted the update on action items being progressed through sub-groups focused on skills, worker protection and housing.

The Working Group will next meet in August 2023.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Joseph Mitchell, Assistant Secretary, Australian Council of Trade Unions
- Fiona Simson, President, National Farmers' Federation
- Ben Rogers, General Manager, Workplace Relations & Legal Affairs, National Farmers' Federation
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- George Robertson, Executive Director - Farms, United Workers Union
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- Patrick Hutchinson, Chief Executive Officer, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Rachel Mackenzie, NFF Horticulture Council member
- Rosemary Deininger, Deputy Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-workforce-working-group-july-2023>